
New Bunny Parent Guide



Everything you need for a happy, confident start together — from shopping lists to first-week wisdom, the Winnie way.

Before Winnie Arrives

The welcome-home shopping list



The essentials

- ☐ A pen or hutch — at least 12 sq ft of living space, plus a linked exercise run of 24+ sq ft
- ☐ Hay rack + unlimited Timothy hay
- ☐ Water bottle or heavy bowl
- ☐ Litter box + paper-based litter (not clay/clumping)
- ☐ At least one hideout
- ☐ Quality rabbit pellets

The happy extras

- ☐ Willow or wood chew toys
- ☐ Tunnels for enrichment
- ☐ Soft grooming brush
- ☐ Small-animal nail clippers
- ☐ An exercise pen for supervised floor time
- ☐ A carrier for vet visits

Winnie's tip

Set up the litter box in a corner of the pen from day one — most rabbits take to litter training quickly once the box is somewhere they already go.



The First Week



Slow and gentle wins every heart

DAYS
1-2

Quiet settling

Have hay and a ready litter box from the start. Keep things calm — rabbits are prey animals and startle easily. Don't be alarmed if they thump once or twice at first — it's a startle response, not aggression, and it'll fade as they settle.

DAYS
3-4

Soft hellos

Sit near their space quietly rather than reaching in repeatedly. Offer a leafy green by hand and let them approach. A cardboard tunnel or box with two openings gives them a sense of control over their space — prey animals love an escape route.

DAYS
5-7

Gentle handling

Begin brief, well-supported handling — always support the hindquarters, never let the back legs dangle or kick free. A binky (a happy little jump-twist) during this stage is a wonderful sign — it means they're starting to feel truly at home.

WEEK
2+

Building trust

Start supervised, bunny-proofed floor time and book a first check-up with a rabbit-savvy vet. This is a good time to ask your vet about spay/neuter timing, if not already done — it matters for litter training and long-term health.



Feeding Basics

Happy tummies, healthy bodies



How much & how often

- 🐾 Hay available 24/7 — it should be about 80% of their diet
- 🐾 Daily greens: romaine or leaf lettuce, plus herbs like cilantro, basil, dill, and thyme (go lighter on parsley and mint, which are higher in calcium)
- 🐾 Pellets measured, not free-fed — about 1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 lbs of body weight per day
- 🐾 Fresh water always available
- 🐾 Introduce new foods gradually — sudden diet changes upset their digestion

Treats (a few times a week, not daily)

- 🐾 Carrots — 1-2 thin slices, just a couple times a week (higher in sugar than leafy greens)
- 🐾 A small apple wedge, seeds removed, only occasionally
- 🐾 A few banana slices or berries as an occasional special treat

Never feed your bunny

- 🐾 Onions, garlic & the allium family
- 🐾 Avocado, chocolate & anything sugary
- 🐾 Dairy or meat of any kind — strict herbivores
- 🐾 Iceberg lettuce (empty calories, diarrhea risk)
- 🐾 Rhubarb & raw beans

If something risky gets eaten

Call your vet or the ASPCA Animal Poison
Control Center right away:

(888) 426-4435 — available 24/7



A Bunny-Safe Home

Curiosity-proofing 101



Plants to keep far away

- 🐾 Lilies, tulips, daffodils & other bulb flowers
- 🐾 Azalea, oleander & foxglove
- 🐾 Any unwashed, unidentified, or pesticide-treated greenery

Safe greenery instead

- 🐾 Basil
- 🐾 Cilantro
- 🐾 Parsley (in moderation)
- 🐾 Mint
- 🐾 Dill
- 🐾 Spider plant (safe ornamental option)

Around the house

- 🐾 Bunny-proof floor-time areas: cords, baseboards & houseplants are fair game to chew
- 🐾 Keep the room cool — rabbits tolerate cold far better than heat (77-80°F max)
- 🐾 Support the hindquarters fully when handling — their spine is surprisingly fragile
- 🐾 Block off small gaps behind furniture where a curious rabbit could get stuck
- 🐾 A litter box in every favorite corner makes accidents far less likely



Cleaning & Care

A simple rhythm keeps everyone healthy



Every day

- 🐾 Scoop the litter box
- 🐾 Rinse and refill the water bottle or bowl
- 🐾 Spot clean the pen or hutch floor

Every week

- 🐾 Full litter box clean with a pet-safe cleaner (skip harsh chemicals)
- 🐾 Full pen/hutch clean: swap bedding and wipe down surfaces
- 🐾 Brush your rabbit — more often during seasonal heavy shedding

Good to know

- 🐾 Nail trims: roughly every 4-6 weeks
- 🐾 Deep-clean hideouts and toys monthly
- 🐾 Check and refill the hay rack throughout the day — hay should never run out



Health & Vet Care

A little routine goes a long way



The usual schedule

- 🐾 A rabbit-savvy vet visit within the first week — not all vets treat rabbits
- 🐾 Annual wellness visits for healthy adults
- 🐾 Ask about spay/neuter — it matters for both health and litter-box behavior

Call the vet if you notice

- ♥ Not eating hay or refusing food for 6+ hours — can signal GI stasis, a real emergency
- ♥ Few or no droppings, or unusually small/dry ones
- ♥ Sneezing, discharge, or noisy breathing
- ♥ Hunched posture, teeth grinding, or a head tilt

My bunny's vet info

Clinic: _____

Phone: _____

Emergency clinic: _____

Phone: _____



Cool Bunny Facts

A little trivia to impress your friends



1

A rabbit's eyes are positioned to give them almost 360-degree vision, all the better to watch for predators.

2

A rabbit's teeth never stop growing for their entire life, which is why constant chewing is a real need, not just a habit.

3

Rabbits can jump nearly 3 feet high and cover about 9 feet in a single leap.

4

A joyful mid-air jump-and-twist is called a 'binky,' and it's one of the clearest signs of rabbit happiness.

5

Rabbits practice cecotrophy — eating special soft droppings called cecotropes directly from their body, which is a normal and essential part of digestion.

6

Rubbing their chin on objects ('chinning') is scent-marking — it's a rabbit's way of claiming territory.

7

A group of rabbits is called a herd or a colony, and baby rabbits are called kits.

8

With good care, pet rabbits commonly live 8-12 years.

9

A rabbit's heart beats over 200 times a minute at rest — much faster than a human's average of 60-100 bpm.

10

A rabbit's large ears aren't just for hearing — they also help release excess body heat through blood vessels near the surface.

